and equitable world order'. Starting with discussion of ties with neighbours in South Asia, these speeches progress outward to other parts of the world: Central Asia, China, East and South-East Asia, Middle East and the Gulf, Russia, Europe, the United States, Africa and Latin America.[3] Also, the head of state reminds members of India's parliament that independence in making decisions on foreign policy remains India's topmost priority in external relations.

STRATEGIC AUTONOMY

The emphasis on independence and strategic autonomy is a throwback to the struggle against British rule. During the Raj, Indians were kept out of decision making and the key demand of India's freedom struggle was the right for Indians to make decisions that affect their lives and their future. The Raj forced Indians to fight distant wars with which they had little to do. While Indians were involved in local government and administration, they had nothing to do with foreign policy, which remained firmly in the hands of colonial officers and administrators.

'What does independence consist of?' Nehru rhetorically asked the Constituent Assembly in March 1949. He then proceeded to reply, 'It consists fundamentally and basically of foreign relations. Once foreign relations go out of your hand into the charge of somebody else, to that extent and in that measure you are not independent.'[4] Thus, freedom was only possible if you could think freely for yourself while making decisions of war and peace and regarding friend or foe. India's founding elite was adamant that independent India would make its own decisions, even if it resulted in occasionally treading a somewhat lonely path. Standing alone at times or standing up to the dominant superpowers has been perceived as a badge of honour by India's leaders.

India's championing of non-alignment followed directly from this desire to make decisions without having to take directions from others. Non-